

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Eight is the most emotionally and interpersonally demanding stage in the program so far. Part 4 in particular, Tricky Moments, deserves a careful read before facilitating this stage for the first time — it covers real situations (genuine tension surfacing during role-play, someone sharing something beyond the scope of a skills exercise) that a facilitator should be prepared for, not improvising in the moment.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five situations that come up often in this stage, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Eight: Soft Skills. Unlike some earlier stages, almost nothing here can be done fully alone — you'll be talking, listening, and practicing with real partners throughout. That's the whole point.”

“Today is about communication and listening specifically. Most of us think we're decent listeners. By the end of today, you'll have real evidence either way, not just an assumption.”

Opening Session 2

“Today shifts inward: emotional intelligence and self-awareness. This is more reflective than last session, and it asks for real honesty with yourself, which is sometimes harder than being honest with someone else.”

“A quick note: nothing today requires sharing your personal reflections with the group unless you want to. The value is in the honesty of what you write, not in performing it for anyone else.”

Opening Session 3

“This is our most direct, interpersonally demanding session in the whole program. We're going to give and receive real feedback, and practice mediating and resolving actual disagreements.”

“Discomfort today is expected and normal, not a sign anything's going wrong. If a moment feels like too much, it's genuinely fine to step back and observe rather than participate in a given exercise.”

Opening Session 4

“Today is genuinely collaborative — we'll be working in small teams for most of the session, not doing individual reflection. You'll stay in the same small group throughout, since several exercises build on each other.”

Opening Session 5

“Today covers networking and public speaking, two skills a lot of people carry real anxiety about. We're going to practice both in low-stakes, supportive settings, specifically because the discomfort fades with genuine repetition.”

“This is our longest session. We'll take a real break partway through, and if energy is flagging, we can split the remainder to a follow-up session.”

Opening Session 6 (Stage Close)

“This is our final session for Stage Eight, focused on growth mindset and resilience. It's also where we look back honestly across everything we've built across all six sessions.”

“Today is mostly individual reflection. Take it seriously — the value of this closing session depends entirely on how honest you're willing to be with yourself.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST L1 → L4

"You've just practiced listening fully before responding. Now let's flip to the other side — how do you communicate your own real needs clearly, without either staying silent or overpowering the conversation?"

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was about how you communicate outward. Next session turns inward — the emotional awareness and self-knowledge that shapes how you communicate in the first place."

FIRST L15 → L16

"You've named a pattern in how you react emotionally. Patience is one of the most common places that pattern shows up under pressure — let's practice it directly."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You now have real language for your own emotions and others' perspectives. Today puts that directly to use in two of the hardest interpersonal moments: feedback and conflict."

FIRST L6 → L3

"You've practiced receiving feedback gracefully. Conflict resolution asks something related but distinct: initiating a hard conversation yourself, not just responding well to one."

Session 3 → Session 4

"You've practiced navigating disagreement one-on-one. Today scales that up — real teamwork, with all the coordination and role dynamics that come with a full group."

FIRST L32 → L18

"You just generated a wide range of ideas without judgment. Problem-solving is the next step: genuinely evaluating and converging on the best path forward together."

Session 4 → Session 5

"You've practiced working well within a team. Today is about showing up, visibly and confidently, beyond your immediate team — in a room, in a conversation, at a podium."

FIRST L12 → L13

"You practiced a genuine, curious networking conversation. Mentoring is a related but deeper relationship — let's look at what it takes to guide someone, not just connect with them."

Session 5 → Session 6

"You've now practiced showing up confidently in front of others. This final session turns the lens back on you — how you handle change, setbacks, and stress, and what you've genuinely taken from this entire stage."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant seems to be performing emotional openness rather than being genuine

No direct callout needed in the moment. Model genuine specificity yourself in your own framing, and give the exercise room — most people naturally settle into real honesty once they see it's actually safe to do so.

Someone becomes visibly upset during a feedback or conflict exercise (Session 3)

"Let's pause for a second. That's a real reaction, and it's okay. Do you want to keep going, take a short break, or switch to observing for this one?" (Always offer the option to step back, genuinely, not as a formality.)

A role-play (L35) starts to feel too real or personal

"Let's step out of the scenario for a moment — remember this is a practice conflict, not a real one between you two. Take a breath, and we'll either reset the scenario or move to a new one."

The room is reluctant to give real, specific feedback during a peer exercise

"Vague, kind feedback doesn't actually help anyone here. Try this frame: one specific thing that worked, one specific thing you'd change. That's it — not a performance review, just two honest observations."

Someone dismisses a soft skill as "not real work" or unnecessary

"That's a fair skepticism, and worth naming. Most people who've been in the workforce a while would say the technical skills got them the job, but the soft skills determined how far they actually went and how much they enjoyed getting there."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific situations where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or genuinely upset — read this section closely before facilitating this stage.

FIRST L2 / L21

Empathy Reflection / Perspective-Taking Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants will use a genuinely painful or unresolved conflict as their example, which can reopen real hurt. Encourage choosing a moderate, somewhat resolved disagreement for this specific exercise, and note that deeper unresolved conflicts are better explored one-on-one with a trusted person, not in a group exercise.

FIRST L6

Feedback Received Gracefully

FACILITATOR NOTE

Defensiveness in this exercise is extremely common and not a character flaw — name that explicitly before starting so people don't feel singled out if it happens to them. The goal is noticing the instinct, not eliminating it instantly.

FIRST L35

Conflict Mediation Role Played

FACILITATOR NOTE

Occasionally a role-played conflict surfaces genuine, real tension between the two participants that existed before the exercise. If this happens, pause the role-play, acknowledge it directly and calmly, and offer a private follow-up conversation rather than continuing to role-play through real unresolved feelings.

FIRST L27

Resilience Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Keep this explicitly scoped to moderate, real but bounded setbacks. If someone shares something clearly beyond the scope of a skills-practice exercise (a major loss, trauma, ongoing crisis), thank them for trusting the group, and gently redirect: “that sounds like something worth real support beyond what we can offer in this format — let's talk after the session about resources.”